The third Ming emperor, Yongle inherited a substantial maritime fleet and major shipbuilding facilities from the earlier Song and Yuan dynasties. We have seen how Chinese ships were already the largest anywhere in the world and incorporated advanced technologies in shipbuilding and navigation. Ibn Battuta's description of Chinese ships at Calicut harbour dates from the Yuan dynasty. It is likely that larger, more impressive ships were constructed at the Nanjing shipyards, especially for Zheng He's voyages, in particular the so-called very large 'treasure ships', which carried royal gifts for rulers in the countries to be visited.

The countries in South-East Asia and the Malabar coast were familiar to the Chinese, who had frequently sailed there. As mentioned earlier, trade with countries in the Persian Gulf, the Arab and African coasts was in the hands of Persian and Arab merchants, who would normally bring their wares to the emporia ports like Calicut and Quilon. From there they would take back Chinese silks, porcelain and a variety of spices, which in turn would have been brought to these cities by ships belonging to the Chinese, Indians and Arabs who handled trade between India and China, and also with South-East Asia. The Malabar ports of Kochi, Quilon and Calicut served as the terminuses for Chinese vessels. There is evidence of permanent Chinese settlements in these cities, just as there were substantial Arab communities in them as well. It should come as no surprise that Calicut was the terminus of Zheng He's voyages and served as the most convenient base for his forays beyond, into the Persian Gulf and the eastern coast of Africa.

Our knowledge about Zheng He's voyages is derived mainly from three documentary sources: 'Overall Survey of the Ocean's Shores (Yingyai Shenglan)', 1433, by Ma Huan; 'Overall Survey of the Starry Rift (Xingcha Shenglan)', 1436, by Fei Xin; and 'Description of Barbarian Countries of the West (Xinyang Fanguo Shi)', 1434, by Gong Zhen.

All three authors accompanied Zheng He on several of the voyages and have left accounts of the places visited. For example, Ma Huan has left a detailed description of Calicut, which not only gives us an idea of the city, its people, its social and economic life and its political dispensation, but